Anthropology - Structural Correspondence with the 5-Stage Model

2026-03-21

Contents

Anthropology . . . 1
Survey Overview . . . 1
Overview of the 5-Stage Model . . . 1
Overview of Structural Correspondences . . . 3
Key Entry 1: Three Phases of Rites of Passage (van Gennep) . . . 3
Key Entry 2: Liminality and Communitas (Turner) . . . 3
Key Entry 3: Four Phases of Social Drama (Turner) . . . 4
Cross-Cutting Patterns . . . 4
Unresolved Questions . . . 5
Conclusion . . . 5

Anthropology

Structural correspondence survey with the 5-stage model (Ba / Wave / En / Uzu / Taba)

Survey Overview

- **Survey target**: 10 major theories in anthropology
- **Research question**: Do the various theories of anthropology correspond structurally to the 5-stage model?
- **Results**: Conditional correspondence in 1 case

Overview of the 5-Stage Model

Stage	Definition
Ba (Field)	An undifferentiated state. The initial condition in which no direction or structure has yet been established
Wave	The exploratory stage in which multiple directions diverge and compete
En (Edge)	A state of tension in which opposing elements coexist without converging on either side. The place where they meet at the boundary, influence each other, and relationships emerge
Uzu (Vortex)	The stage in which a new coherence (order) arises spontaneously from within the tension
Taba (Bundle)	The stage in which the form is fixed and stabilizes as a reusable structure

---

Figure 1: Domain — Research Overview Infographic

Figure 2: Domain — Theory x 5-Stage Correspondence Matrix

Overview of Structural Correspondences

Confidence	Theory group	Positioning
Near-established	Rites of passage (van Gennep), Social drama (Turner), Liminality and communitas (Turner), Purity and taboo (Douglas)	Direct structural correspondence of Wave→En→Uzu is confirmed at the level of primary sources
Compelling	Ethnic boundaries (Barth), The gift (Mauss), Chaîne opératoire (Leroi-Gourhan / Lemonnier), Symbolic and social boundaries (Lamont & Molnar), Structuration theory / practical sense (Giddens / Bourdieu)	Correspondence exists, but interpretive supplementation is needed for some stages
Conditional	Contact zone (Pratt)	Correspondence with En is strong, but correspondence with other stages exceeds the descriptive scope of the theory

---

Key Entry 1: Three Phases of Rites of Passage (van Gennep)

- In 1909, van Gennep organized rites of passage into three phases: "separation (detachment from the old state)," "transition/margin," and "incorporation (integration into the new state)." This three-phase arrangement is a structure that repeats at life-cycle turning points such as birth, coming of age, marriage, and death. What van Gennep himself emphasized was that the essence of ritual lies not in individual elements but in the "relative position (order)" within the ritual as a whole.
- **As a matter of fact**: In van Gennep's primary text, it is explicitly stated that the transitional period (transition) is in some cases inserted as a "secondary autonomous system." For example, in novitiate or betrothal, the interior of the transitional period is further staged as "sacralization → transition → desacralization." In other words, transition is not a moment but a band that requires a certain duration and sequence of operations.
- **As an interpretation of structure**: Here we read the band-like transitional structure inserted between the old and new states. The level of similarity is process, with particular attention to "transition having an autonomous sequence of operations." The internal staging of the transitional period demonstrates a fractal-like property in which the same structure repeats at a smaller scale.
- **As an interpretive reading**: Separation corresponds to Wave (making latent differences manifest through detachment from existing order); the margin corresponds to En (reconstitution of relationships in a boundary zone that belongs to neither the old nor the new state); and incorporation corresponds to Uzu (arising as a new status or state). The primary source's description that the margin is not merely a point of contact but an "operational band" is the anthropological basis for En in the 5-stage model being not a moment but a domain containing duration and operation. Correspondence with Ba (undifferentiated membership in the old state) and Taba (institutionalization of the rite of passage as a repeated pattern of social structure) is somewhat thin from van Gennep's own description, but has been supplemented in subsequent research.

Key Entry 2: Liminality and Communitas (Turner)

- In *The Ritual Process* (1969), Turner thematized the characteristics of the liminal period (liminal phase) among van Gennep's three phases. Liminality refers to the ambiguous state in which someone undergoing a rite of passage deviates from the web of classification systems, placed in a state of "betwixt and between." In this state, secular distinctions (class, status, property) are nullified, and an equal and direct communality appears among participants. Turner called this communality communitas.

- **As a matter of fact**: The liminal being does not fit into any of the existing classification categories. It is characterized by metaphors of "death, womb, invisibility, darkness, androgyny, wilderness." Within this categorical deviation, a generative process of stripping the old state, homogenization, and reformation toward a new state unfolds. Communitas is contrasted with institutionalized hierarchy (structure), and the dialectical alternation of structure and anti-structure is the skeleton of Turner's theory.
- **As an interpretation of structure**: Here we read the dual movement of existing classification systems being dismantled, and new relationality emerging within that dismantling. The level of similarity is structure, and attention is given not merely to the closeness of terminology but to the relational arrangement in which "the dismantling of classification" and "the emergence of new communality" occur simultaneously.
- **As an interpretive reading**: Liminality is the theory that most precisely describes what is occurring within En of the 5-stage model. Deviation from the classification system corresponds to the dissolution of the existing Ba; communitas corresponds to the emergence of new relationality; and reformation corresponds to the arising of Uzu. "Betwixt and between" directly corresponds to the essential characteristic of En — the state of not belonging to any existing category. The alternation of structure and anti-structure is structurally similar to the cyclic structure of the 5 stages (Taba → Ba → Wave → En → Uzu → Taba).

Key Entry 3: Four Phases of Social Drama (Turner)

- In *Dramas, Fields, and Metaphors* (1974), Turner presented the concept of social drama. Social drama is the unit in which the breach of normative order unfolds as a public process. It consists of four phases: first, breach of norm; second, mounting crisis; third, redressive action; fourth, reintegration or schism.
- **As a matter of fact**: Turner explicitly states that the crisis and redressive phases have a "liminal" character. This allows the concept of liminality to extend beyond the interior of ritual to social processes in general. The scope of redress extends from personal advice to legal instruments and public rituals. And importantly, redress does not necessarily lead to reintegration — the model inherently contains the branching outcome of schism.
- **As an interpretation of structure**: Here we read the process in which the development of social conflict proceeds in stages, and the redressive phase functions as "redesign of relationships." The level of similarity is process, with particular attention to the liminal character of the redressive phase and the inherent presence of the failed branch of schism.
- **As an interpretive reading**: The escalation from breach of norm to mounting crisis corresponds to Wave (amplification of turbulence); redressive action corresponds to En (the liminal phase in which redesign of relationships takes place); and reintegration corresponds to Uzu (the arising of new order). Schism can be interpreted in the 5-stage model as "the case where Wave did not become Uzu." Among the many process models that describe only the success path, the fact that social drama incorporates schism as a constituent element of the theory is theoretically important for testing the robustness of the 5-stage model.

Cross-Cutting Patterns

- The pattern that recurs most overwhelmingly across anthropology is the sheer thickness of En
- This multifaceted nature shows that En in the 5-stage model is not a simple concept
- Contrasting Turner's liminality (the generative aspect of En) with Douglas's pollution (the destructive and dangerous aspect of En) brings out the ambivalence of En
- While anthropological theories have overwhelming density in En, correspondence with Ba and Taba tends to be relatively weak

---

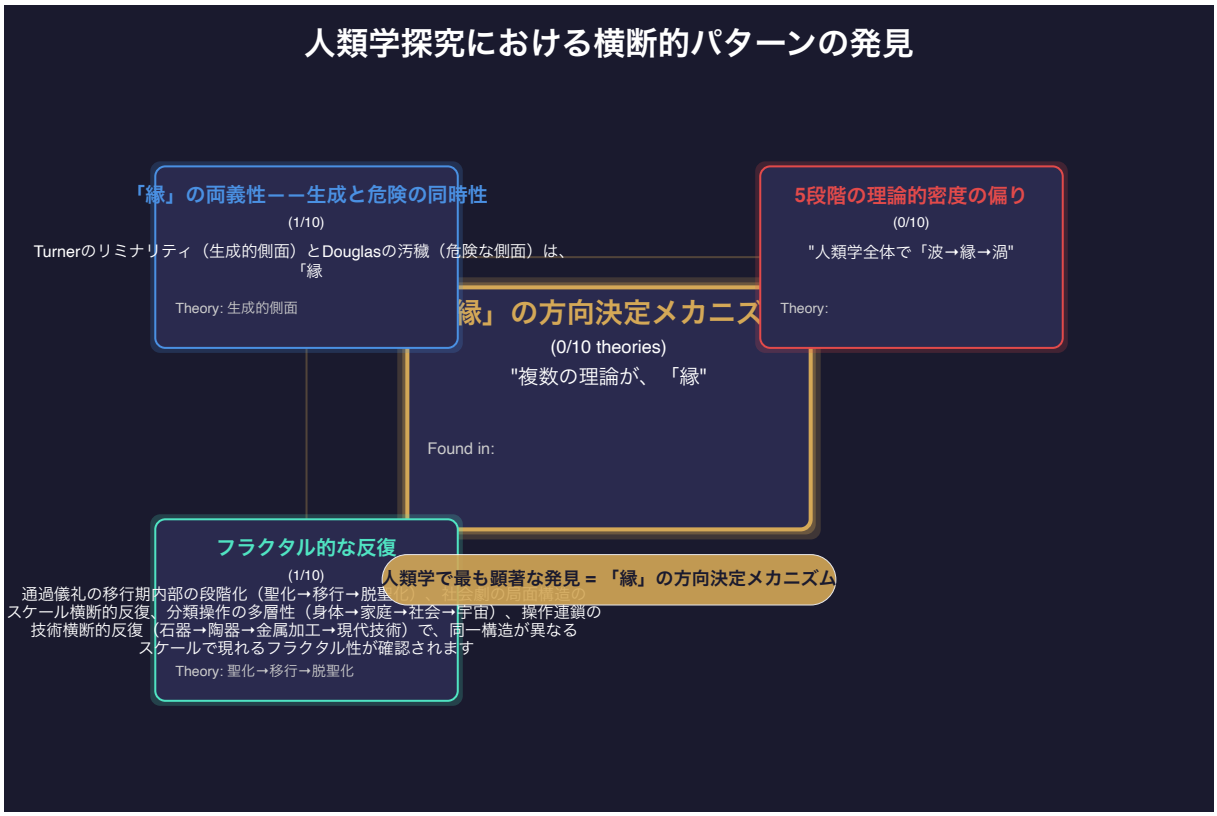

Figure 3: Domain — Cross-Cutting Patterns Diagram

Unresolved Questions

- How to integrate the "multifaceted nature of En." Across anthropology alone, 8 "faces of En" have been identified, but whether an integrative higher-level classification is possible remains unresolved. Contrast with types found in other domains (e.g., the 4 types of threshold, competitive, interfacial, and propagation identified in complexity science) is also a remaining task.
- The anthropological description of Ba is structurally insufficient. Since anthropology is a discipline focused on "boundaries," the theoretical insufficiency of "the undifferentiated state prior to boundaries" is a domain-specific limitation. There is a possibility of supplementing through connection with other domains (the mathematical concept of "field," the chemical concept of "reaction field," etc.).
- The relationship between liminality and liminoid requires careful examination. Turner's own "extension from liminal (obligatory, collective ritual) to liminoid (optional, individual experience)" is a concept that opens up application to post-industrial society, but confirmation at the primary source level remains partial.
- Barth's theory of ethnic boundaries demonstrates a "persistence of En" that strongly suggests the 5-stage model is not a unidirectional progression, but how to describe the relationship between the persistence of En and Uzu/Taba is a matter with conflicting interpretations remaining.

Conclusion

- This survey confirmed that anthropology is a domain with overall strong structural similarity to the 5-stage model
- Near-established correspondence is found in the lineages of van Gennep's rites of passage, Turner's liminality and communitas, Turner's social drama, and Douglas's purity and taboo
- The greatest insight to be gained from anthropology is the conceptual richness of En
- The remaining question is how to integrate this "multifaceted nature of En" and connect it with the "types of En" found in other domains